Reading Comprehension: Fiction & Poetry

Year 4 Pt 2 · **Homework Worksheet**

Worked Example

Figurative Language: Extract: 'The waves clawed at the cliff, patient and relentless.' Identify the personification and explain its effect.

Answer: The waves are personified as 'clawing' at the cliff, as if they were a clawed animal attacking it; this emphasises how powerful, persistent and almost deliberate the erosion of the cliff seems.

Literal Retrieval & Vocabulary (15 questions)

1. Extract: 'Zara dug her toes into the warm sand and watched a crab scuttle sideways into a hole. Further out, her brother was waist-deep, waving for her to join him.' What was the crab doing?
2. In the beach extract, where was Zara's brother?
3. In the beach extract, what does 'scuttle' suggest about the way the crab moved? A) Quick, scurrying, sideways movement B) Slow, heavy movement C) Flying movement D) No movement at all E) Swimming movement
4. Extract: 'The kitchen smelled of cinnamon and burnt toast. Nana was humming an old tune, flour dusted across her apron like fresh snow.' Name two things, according to the extract, that could be smelled in the kitchen.
5. In the kitchen extract, what was Nana doing?
6. In the kitchen extract, what does the comparison 'flour dusted across her apron like fresh snow' suggest about the flour? A) It lightly covered her apron in a thin white layer B) It had turned her apron completely black C) It was invisible D) It had melted away E) It was the colour of ash
7. Extract: 'Two boys argued over whose turn it was on the swing, while a younger girl sat cross-legged in the sandpit, carefully building a tower of pebbles.' What were the two boys arguing about?
8. In the playground extract, what was the younger girl doing?
9. Select ALL that apply, based on the playground extract: which of these are mentioned? A) Two boys arguing B) A girl building with pebbles C) A dog running past D) A swing E) Rain starting to fall
10. Poem fragment: 'The lighthouse blinks its single eye / Across the restless, rolling sea, / A steady friend to ships that sigh / And sailors longing to be free.' According to the poem fragment, what does the lighthouse do?
11. What kind of sea is described in the lighthouse poem fragment?
12. In the lighthouse poem fragment, what does describing the sea as 'restless' suggest? A) The sea is constantly moving and never still B) The sea is completely calm C) The sea is frozen D) The sea is shrinking E) The sea is silent
13. Extract: 'Mr Adeyemi tapped the whiteboard twice and the room fell silent. "Books away," he said. "Today we're doing something different."' What did Mr Adeyemi do before the room fell silent?
14. In the classroom extract, what instruction did Mr Adeyemi give the class?
15. In the classroom extract, what does the phrase 'something different' suggest is about to happen in the lesson? A) An unusual change from the normal lesson routine B) The class is cancelled C) A fire drill is about to start D) The teacher is leaving the school E) Nothing out of the ordinary

Inference, Mood & Character (15 questions)

1. Extract: 'Dev's pencil hovered over the first question. His leg bounced under the desk, and he kept glancing at the clock as if willing it to slow down.' What can you infer about how Dev is feeling before his exam?

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2. In the Dev extract, which detail best shows his nervousness? A) His leg bouncing under the desk B) His pencil being blue C) The question being easy D) The clock being broken E) Him smiling calmly

3. In the Dev extract, why might Dev keep glancing at the clock?

4. Extract: 'Ever since the baby arrived, Amir had been quieter than usual. He still smiled when anyone mentioned his little sister, but sometimes, when no one was looking, his smile faded.' What can you infer about Amir's true feelings about his new sister?

5. In the Amir extract, what does the detail about his smile fading 'when no one was looking' suggest? A) He hides some of his true feelings in front of others B) He never actually likes his sister C) He is always cheerful with no hidden feelings D) He is pretending to be quiet on purpose for attention E) He dislikes smiling in general

6. In the Amir extract, what change in his behaviour is described since the baby arrived?

7. Extract: 'Every time thunder rumbled, Leah pulled her blanket tighter and counted slowly to ten, the way her mum had taught her.' What can you infer about Leah's feelings about thunderstorms?

8. Select ALL that apply, based on the Leah extract: which statements are supported by it? A) She is afraid of thunder. B) Her mum taught her a coping strategy. C) She enjoys thunderstorms. D) She counts to calm herself down. E) She is alone in the house.

9. In the Leah extract, what method does she use to cope with the thunder?

10. Poem fragment: 'Though the branches here are bare, / And winter holds the garden still, / I know that green will soon be there — / Spring always climbs the hill.' What does this poem fragment suggest about the speaker's outlook or mood?

11. What is the overall mood of the spring poem fragment? A) Hopeful B) Despairing C) Angry D) Terrified E) Mocking

12. What season is currently described in the spring poem fragment, and what is the speaker confident will follow?

13. Extract: 'Coach Ellis didn't shout when the team lost. She simply gathered them in a circle and asked, "What's one thing we did well today?" One by one, hands went up.' What does Coach Ellis's reaction suggest about her character or coaching style?

14. In the Coach Ellis extract, what question did she ask the team after they lost?

15. In the Coach Ellis extract, what does the detail 'one by one, hands went up' suggest about the team's response? A) The players felt able to engage positively despite the loss B) The players refused to answer C) The players were angry with Coach Ellis D) The players left the circle E) The players argued with each other

Standard / Advanced (15 questions)

1. In the line 'The silence screamed louder than any shout,' what contradiction makes this an example of oxymoron, and what feeling might it suggest?

2. If a character is described as having 'a voice like gravel,' what does this simile most likely suggest about the voice? A) It is rough, harsh, and may hint at an older or more weathered speaker B) It is high-pitched and delicate C) It is completely silent D) It is melodic and soft like a song E) It belongs to a baby

3. A poem calls autumn leaves 'dying embers of summer.' What does this metaphor suggest about both the leaves' colour and the ending of a season?

4. In 'He wore his pride like armour,' what does the simile suggest the pride is protecting him from, as well as what it might be hiding?

5. If the wind is personified as 'combing its fingers through the long grass,' what two ideas does this personification combine?

6. Extract: 'The old sailor's face was a map of scars and sunburnt wrinkles, each line telling a story of some forgotten storm. His eyes, pale as sea-glass, had watched fifty years of tides come and go, yet they still lit up like

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a boy's whenever someone mentioned the sea.' Identify TWO similes or metaphors in this extract and explain what each compares.

7. In the sailor extract, what do the combined images suggest about the sailor's character? A) He is an experienced, weathered man who still retains a youthful passion for the sea B) He has never been to sea C) He dislikes the sea and wants to forget it D) He is a very young man pretending to be old E) He has lost all memory of his past

8. In the sailor extract, explain why the metaphor 'a map of scars' is an effective way to describe his face.

9. Extract: 'The city never slept. Neon signs blinked like tired eyes, and the traffic roared on, an endless river of light and noise flowing between the buildings.' Identify the personification and the metaphor in this extract.

10. Select ALL that apply, based on the city extract: which statements are true about the figurative language used? A) The city is personified as never sleeping. B) The traffic is compared to a river using a metaphor. C) The neon signs are compared to eyes using a simile. D) The extract contains no figurative language. E) The buildings are described as roaring.

11. Taken together, what overall impression of the city do the images in the city extract create? A) A restless, constantly active and overwhelming place B) A peaceful, sleepy village C) An abandoned, empty ghost town D) A quiet, rural landscape E) A silent library

12. Extract: 'Grief sat on her shoulders like a sack of stones, heavier some days than others, but never light enough to set down completely.' Identify the simile in this extract and explain what it compares grief to.

13. In the grief extract, explain what the detail 'heavier some days than others, but never light enough to set down completely' suggests about how grief changes over time.

14. Extract: 'The old oak had seen a hundred summers come and go. Its branches, like gnarled old hands, reached out over the lane as though trying to shelter every traveller who passed beneath.' Identify the simile and the personification used to describe the oak tree.

15. In the oak tree extract, what impression of the tree do the simile and personification together create? A) An ancient, protective, almost human presence watching over the lane B) A young, fragile sapling C) A dangerous, menacing tree D) A tree that is dying and leafless E) A tree with no connection to the people nearby

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